Righteousness

Gospel Movements in the Arc of God's Righteousness

But now apart from the law the righteousness of God (although it is attested by the law and the prophets) has been disclosed – namely, the righteousness of God through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction, for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God. But they are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus. (Romans 3:21-24)

https://tinyurl.com/RightWithGod

Central thesis: God's righteousness is not achieved by man. It is revealed in Christ, received by faith, implanted through new birth, and lived out through sanctification.

The Gospel Movement of God's Righteousness

Main question: How does God move a sinner from guilt to holy living?

The movement is from **revelation**, to **declaration**, to **regeneration**, to **transformation**.

These four themes belong together, not as separate doctrines only, but as **one unified work of God**.

Christ Reveals the Righteousness of God

The Revelation Gospel Movement

Rom 3:21-24 *But now apart from the law the righteousness of God (although it is attested by the law and the prophets) has been disclosed – namely, the righteousness of God through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction, for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God. But they are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.*

2 Cor 5:21 *God made the one who did not know sin to be sin for us, so that in him we would become the righteousness of God.*

- Jesus fulfills and embodies God's righteousness.
- In Christ, God's justice and mercy are revealed together.
- The cross is the decisive display of God's saving righteousness.
- Christ is not merely a teacher of righteousness; He is the center of it.
- This means righteousness is grounded in a person, not in human effort.

God's character: When you look at Jesus, especially at the cross, what kind of God is revealed there, and how do His justice and mercy meet in Christ?

God's purpose: If God chose to reveal His righteousness in a person rather than through human effort, what does that show about what He wants to accomplish in saving people?

This section presents Christ as the center of God's saving righteousness.

God's character: When you look at Jesus—especially at the cross—what kind of God is revealed there, and how do His justice and mercy meet in Christ?

God's purpose: If God chose to reveal His righteousness in a person rather than through human effort, what does that show about what He wants to accomplish in saving people?

Justification: God Declares Sinners Righteous by Faith

The Declaration Gospel Movement

Rom 5:1 *Therefore, since we have been declared righteous by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ…*

Tit 3:4-7 *But "when the kindness of God our Savior and his love for mankind appeared, he saved us not by works of righteousness that we have done but on the basis of his mercy, through the washing of the new birth and the renewing of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us in full measure through Jesus Christ our Savior. And so, since we have been justified by his grace, we become heirs with the confident expectation of eternal life."*

- Because of Christ, God can declare the guilty righteous without compromising His holiness.
- Justification is received by faith, not earned by works.
- It gives peace with God, assurance before God, and humility before others.
- Faith is not merit; it is trust in Christ's completed work.
- This keeps salvation rooted in mercy, not performance.
- The course outline also frames this as a major apostolic and early Christian emphasis.

God's purpose: Why do you think God designed salvation to be received by faith rather than earned by performance, and how does that shape peace, assurance, and humility in His people?

This section emphasizes that God justifies sinners because of Christ, by faith, through mercy rather than works.

God's character: What does justification by faith reveal about God's holiness, mercy, and willingness to receive guilty people without lowering His standard?

God's purpose: Why do you think God designed salvation to be received by faith rather than earned by performance, and how does that shape peace, assurance, and humility in His people?

The Gift of Righteousness Includes New Birth

The Regeneration Gospel Movement

John 3:3-6 *Jesus replied, "I tell you the solemn truth, unless a person is born from above, he cannot see the kingdom of God." Nicodemus said to him, "How can a man be born when he is old? He cannot enter his mother's womb and be born a second time, can he?" Jesus answered, "I tell you the solemn truth, unless a person is born of water and spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. What is born of the flesh is flesh, and what is born of the Spirit is spirit.*

1 Peter 1:23 *You have been born anew, not from perishable but from imperishable seed, through the living and enduring word of God.*

- God does more than change our standing; He creates new life in us.
- The Spirit brings birth from above.
- The Word of God becomes the living seed of this new life.
- New birth produces new desires, new affections, and a new orientation toward God.
- The believer does not merely receive a verdict; he begins to live from a new inner life.

God's purpose: Why do you think God's goal is not only to forgive us, but also to create new desires, new affections, and a new direction within us?

This section moves from a changed standing before God to new life through the Spirit and the living word.

God's character: What does the need for new birth reveal about how deeply God desires to heal, renew, and transform us?

God's purpose: Why do you think God's goal is not only to forgive us, but also to create new desires, new affections, and a new direction within us?

Sanctification: Living Out God's Righteousness

The Transformation Gospel Movement

Rom 6:10-14 *For the death he died, he died to sin once for all, but the life he lives, he lives to God. So, you too consider yourselves dead to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus. Therefore, do not let sin reign in your mortal body so that you obey its desires, and do not present your members to sin as instruments to be used for unrighteousness, but present yourselves to God as those who are alive from the dead and your members to God as instruments to be used for righteousness. For sin will have no mastery over you, because you are not under law but under grace.*

Eph 4:22-24 *You were taught with reference to your former way of life to lay aside the old man who is being corrupted in accordance with deceitful desires, to be renewed in the spirit of your mind, and to put on the new man who has been created in God's image – in righteousness and holiness that comes from truth.*

- The life God gives begins to shape the life the believer lives.
- Sanctification is the ongoing work of presenting ourselves to God as instruments of righteousness.
- It involves renewal of the mind, putting off the old self, and putting on the new self.
- Holiness is the fruit of grace, not the basis of acceptance.
- Growth in righteousness is progressive, practical, and Spirit-enabled.

This section describes sanctification as God's ongoing work of forming His righteousness in us over time.

God's character: What does **sanctification teach us** about God's patience, faithfulness, and commitment to keep working in His people?

God's purpose: How does seeing **holiness as the fruit of grace, not the basis of acceptance,** change the way we understand God's purpose in obedience, correction, and everyday growth?

One Unified Gospel Arc of Movements

God's Plan to Restore His Human Family

The Gospel Narrative

- Christ reveals God's righteousness.
- Justification receives God's righteousness.
- New birth implants God's righteousness as new life.
- Sanctification expresses God's righteousness in character and conduct.

Key Contrasts

- Not human achievement, but divine provision.
- Not works as the basis, but faith as the means.
- Not outward conformity alone, but inward transformation.
- Not a one-time decision only, but a life continually shaped by grace.

Summary

- God's righteousness is revealed in Christ, credited through faith, planted in us by the Spirit, and lived out in holiness.
- The believer does not move beyond grace after conversion; he grows deeper into it.